

Eikonal Equation as a Bridge to Schrödinger's Equation

Classical Limit and JWKB Approximation

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October 8, 2025

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INTERNATIONAL YEAR OF
Quantum Science
and Technology



Outline

1. Main Idea
2. Historical Roots
3. JWKB Method
4. Conclusions and Future Work
5. References

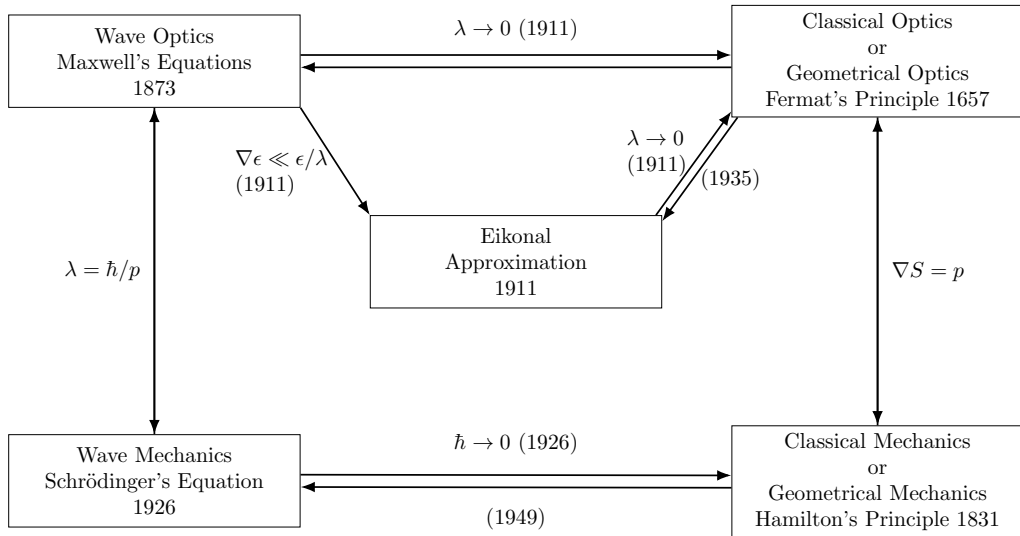


Figure 1: Map of equivalences. Adapted from Gilmore [12].

Main Idea

The Central Analogy

$$\frac{\text{Quantum Mechanics}}{\text{Classical Mechanics}} = \frac{\text{Wave Optics}}{\text{Geometric Optics}}$$

Quantum Mechanics is to Classical Mechanics as
Wave Optics is to Geometric Optics.

- $\lambda \rightarrow 0 \implies \text{Wave Opt.} \rightarrow \text{Geometric Opt.}$
- $\hbar \rightarrow 0 \implies \text{Quantum Mech.} \rightarrow \text{Classical Mech.}$

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Historical Roots

Geometrical Optics

- Obeys Fermat's principle.
- Leads to the **Eikonal equation**:

$$(\nabla S)^2 = \frac{n^2}{c^2} \left(\frac{\partial S}{\partial t} \right)^2$$

Classical Mechanics

- Obeys the Principle of Least Action.
- Leads to the **Hamilton-Jacobi equation**:

$$(\nabla S)^2 = -2m \left(\frac{\partial S}{\partial t} + U \right)$$

Where S is the Classical Action.

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Hamilton's Analogy

The Eikonal and stationary Hamilton-Jacobi equations are formally identical.

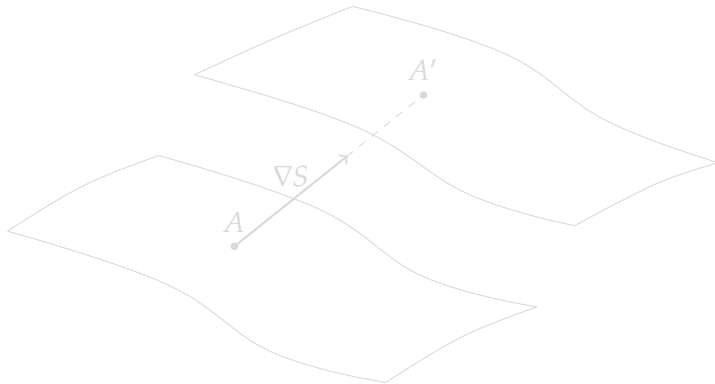


Figure 2: Displacement of a constant action surface after a time interval δt .

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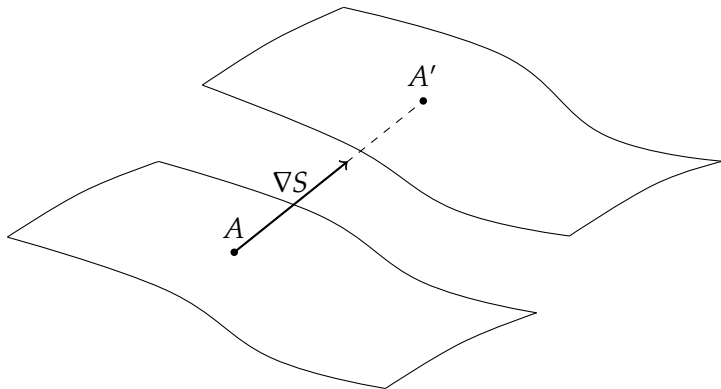
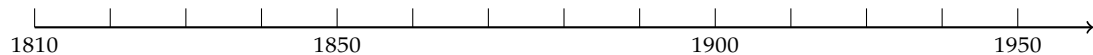


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JWKB Approximation – A Brief History



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Francesco Carlini (1789–1862)



Italian Astronomer

1810

1850

1950

JWKB Approximation – A Brief History

Carlini – (1817)



1810

1850

1900

1950

JWKB Approximation – A Brief History

Carlini – (1817)



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Joseph Liouville (1809–1882)



French Mathematician

George Green (1793–1841)



British Mathematician

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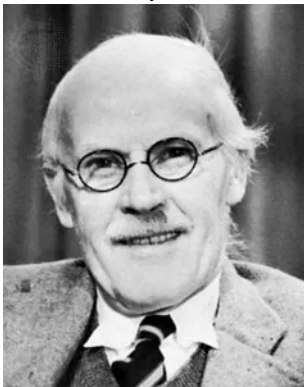
Carlini – (1817)



Liouville – (1837)



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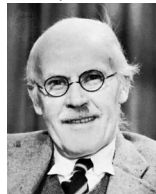
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Liouville – (1837)

Gregor Wentzel (1898–1978)



German Physicist



Hans Kramers (1894–1952)



Dutch Physicist

Jeffreys – (1924)

Léon Brillouin (1889–1969)



French Physicist

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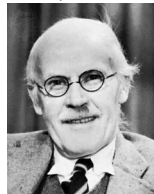
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Wentzel – (1926)



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Brillouin – (1926)



JWKB Method

The Mathematical Setup

Problem: Perturbation of the Highest Derivative

Consider a second-order ODE where a small parameter $\epsilon \ll 1$ multiplies the highest derivative:

$$\epsilon^2 \frac{d^2 y}{dx^2} - Q(x)y = 0$$

This is a **singular perturbation problem**.

The JWKB Ansatz

We seek a solution of the form:

$$y(x) \sim \exp \left[\frac{1}{\epsilon} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \epsilon^n S_n(x) \right]$$

This form captures the rapid, oscillatory behavior dictated by the $1/\epsilon$ term.

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Recovering Classical Mechanics

1. **Start** with the time-dependent Schrödinger equation:

$$i\hbar \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial t} = \left(-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \nabla^2 + V(\mathbf{r}, t) \right) \psi$$

2. Apply the JWKB ansatz, treating the phase S as the action:

$$\psi(\mathbf{r}, t) = A \exp \left(\frac{iS(\mathbf{r}, t)}{\hbar} \right)$$

3. Substitute the ansatz into the Schrödinger equation.

$$\frac{1}{2m} (\nabla S)^2 + V + \frac{\partial S}{\partial t} = \frac{i\hbar}{2m} \nabla^2 S$$

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$$\underbrace{\frac{1}{2m}(\nabla S)^2 + V}_{\text{Hamiltonian } H} + \frac{\partial S}{\partial t} = \underbrace{\frac{i\hbar}{2m}\nabla^2 S}_{\rightarrow 0 \text{ as } \hbar \rightarrow 0}$$

5 **Result:** We recover the classical Hamilton-Jacobi equation.

$$H(\mathbf{r}, \nabla S, t) + \frac{\partial S}{\partial t} = 0$$

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Interplay Between Maths and Physics

The Mathematical Condition

The first-order condition requires:

$$|\epsilon S_2(x)| \ll |S_1(x)|$$

The Physical Picture

Local de Broglie wavelength,
 $\lambda(x) = h/p(x)$:

$$\left| \frac{d\lambda(x)}{dx} \right| \ll 1$$

The Core Idea

The approximation holds when the potential $V(x)$ changes so slowly that the particle's momentum (and thus its wavelength) remains **almost constant** over the distance of a single wavelength.

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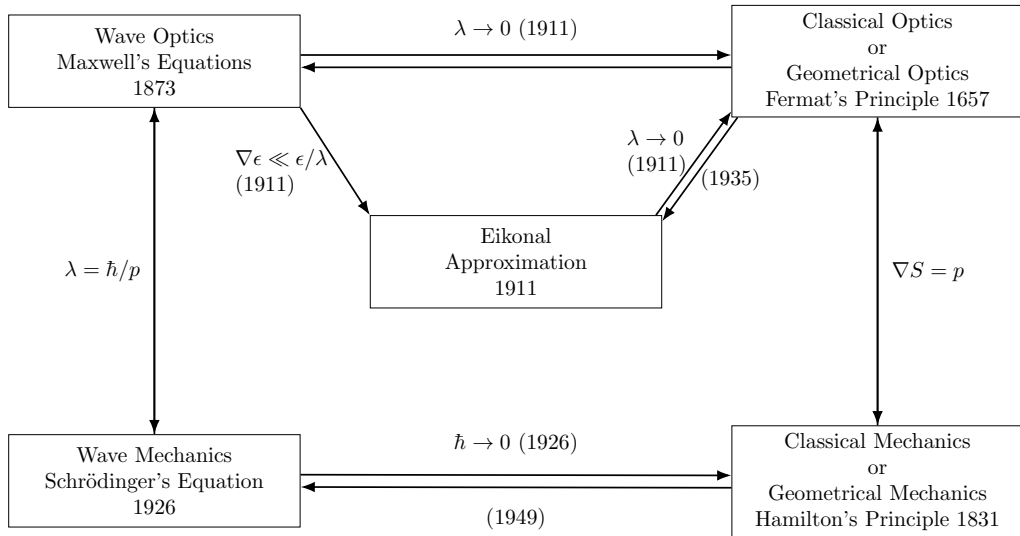


Figure 3: Map of equivalences. Adapted from Gilmore [12].

Conclusions and Future Work

The Central Takeaway

The formal identity between the **Eikonal equation** (Optics) and the **Hamilton-Jacobi equation** (Mechanics) is profound, not coincidental.

- This analogy guided de Broglie and Schrödinger to the **wave theory of matter**.
- The **JWKB approximation** shows classical trajectories emerging as the leading-order of QM in the limit $\hbar \rightarrow 0$.
- Classical Mechanics is the **geometrical optics** of the underlying wave mechanics (Schrödinger's Eq.).

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Geometric & Symplectic Methods

- H-J theory as a gateway to:
- **Symplectic & Contact Geometry**
- Goal: Coordinate-independent descriptions of dynamics.

Semi-classical Methods in QFT

- Apply to **Supersymmetric (SUSY) theories**.
- **SWKB** approximation can yield exact results.
- Powerful tool for non-perturbative effects.

Relativistic Semi-Classics

- Extend from the Schrödinger to the **Dirac equation**.
- Develop semi-classical propagators for spin-1/2 particles.
- Derive classical spin dynamics, e.g., the **BMT equation**.

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Questions or Comments?

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